Ariana Grande Leads a Starry Christmas Carol on The Tonight Show

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It is beginning to sound a lot like Christmas on late-night TV. Pop star Ariana Grande teamed up with her movie **co-stars** Robert De Niro and Ben Stiller for a surprise Christmas **carol** on The Tonight Show Starring Jimmy Fallon on Sunday night.

The trio sang the traditional tune 'O Christmas Tree' to ring in the holiday season. Grande took the lead on vocals, of course, and the audience could not help applauding when she hit those high notes. Stiller gave a **valiant** effort on his part of the song. As for De Niro, well, you will have to watch the clip to see how his turn plays out.

The performance was part of the show's celebration of the arrival of the 2026 Rockefeller Center Christmas tree this weekend. The **episode** aired at 11:35 p.m. ET, right after the Buccaneers vs. Bears football game on NBC, and also featured rapper Lil Baby as the musical guest.

The stars were on the show to promote their new movie, Focker-in-Law, which opens in **theatres** on November 25. It is the latest film in the popular Meet the Parents series. Grande plays Olivia Jones, who is dating Henry, the now grown-up son of Greg and Pam Focker, played by Stiller and Teri Polo. Skyler Gisondo plays Henry.

The three stars chatted with Fallon throughout the **episode**. It was the second of four special Tonight Show **episodes** airing after NBC's Sunday Night Football broadcasts this season. The first aired on September 27, with Sylvester Stallone and Luke Bryan as guests. The next one, on November 15, will feature Jennifer Lopez and Anthony Mackie, plus a musical performance from Quavo. One more is planned for January 10, with guests still to be announced.

Word Treasure

carol -- A traditional song sung at Christmas time.
valiant -- Brave and determined, trying hard even when something is difficult.
co-stars -- Actors who star in the same film or show together.
theatres -- Places where people go to watch films on a big screen.
episode -- One single show in a series of TV programmes.

Background you need

A Christmas carol is a traditional song sung at Christmas time, and 'O Christmas Tree' is one of the best known.

A late-night talk show is a TV show that airs late in the evening, with a host who chats with famous guests and presents music and comedy.

The Rockefeller Center Christmas tree is a huge tree put up every year in New York City, and its arrival marks the start of the holiday season.

Movie stars often visit talk shows to tell audiences about a new film they are in.

Break it down

LEAD: Ariana Grande teamed up with Robert De Niro and Ben Stiller for a surprise Christmas carol on The Tonight Show.

KEY EVENT: The trio sang 'O Christmas Tree' to celebrate the arrival of the Rockefeller Center Christmas tree.

+- WHO: Ariana Grande, Robert De Niro, Ben Stiller and host Jimmy Fallon, with rapper Lil Baby as musical guest.

+- WHEN: The episode aired on Sunday night at 11:35 p.m. ET, after the Buccaneers vs. Bears game.

EVIDENCE: Grande took the lead on vocals and the audience applauded her high notes, while Stiller gave a valiant effort.

OPEN QUESTION: How will De Niro's turn play out? Viewers will have to watch the clip to see.

Why it matters

Christmas carols and holiday traditions bring people together, and this story shows how stars from different generations can share a fun moment on live TV.

Test what you remember

1. Who sang 'O Christmas Tree' on the show?

(A) Ariana Grande, Robert De Niro and Ben Stiller
(B) Jennifer Lopez and Anthony Mackie
(C) Jimmy Fallon and Lil Baby
(D) Sylvester Stallone and Luke Bryan

2. On which show did they perform?

(A) Saturday Night Live
(B) Sunday Night Football
(C) The Voice
(D) The Tonight Show Starring Jimmy Fallon

3. What was the performance celebrating?

(A) A new album by Lil Baby
(B) The end of the year
(C) The start of the football season
(D) The arrival of the Rockefeller Center Christmas tree

4. When does Focker-in-Law open in theatres?

(A) January 10
(B) November 15
(C) September 27
(D) November 25

5. Who does Grande play in the movie?

(A) Henry
(B) Pam Focker
(C) Teri Polo
(D) Olivia Jones

6. When is the next special Tonight Show episode?

(A) December 26
(B) November 25
(C) January 10
(D) November 15

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: D 3: D 4: D 5: D 6: D

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):